



IGA'S FIFTH GRAND SLAM SINGLES TITLE TIED HER WITH BOTH MARIA SHARAPOVA AND MARTINA HINGIS

At 2-all, the point of the match, a ferocious 25-shot power rally, ended when the stronger and faster Pole belted a crosscourt backhand into the open court. Paolini can play incredible defence, but these days, even on clay, excellent offence beats excellent defence.

After Świątek took the opening set 6-2, NBC analyst Mary Carillo posed a

timeless question. "How can Paolini get the greatest reward with the least risk?" There simply was no solution as the toughest challenge in the sport got even tougher in the second set.

With the ruthless efficiency of a fictional gynoid in a baseball cap, Świątek overpowered the merely human Paolini for a predictable 6-2, 6-1 triumph.

Iga's fifth Grand Slam singles title tied her with both Maria Sharapova and Martina Hingis and made her the heavy favorite to win her first gold medal at the Olympics in late July at Roland Garros.

The gap between the 5'9" Pole and the rest of the field on the Paris *terre battue* (clay) was highlighted when she demolished 2019 runner-up Marketa Vondrousova 6-0, 6-2 in the quarterfinals and took out 2022 finalist Coco Gauff 6-2, 6-4 in the penultimate round.

It takes a power hitter to stop the Świątek juggernaut as Rybakina (4-2 against her) and Sabalenka (3-8) have done. Naomi Osaka, with four Grand Slam titles on hard courts, possesses as much all-court power as anyone.

Territorial advantage: Świątek is now the favourite to win her first gold medal at the Olympics at Roland Garros late July. GETTY IMAGES